SURE OF APPLAUSE

HUNGRY FOR QUALITY CONTENT, OTT PLATFORMS HAVE FOUND IN APPLAUSE ENTERTAINMENT A RELIABLE SUPPLIER



FRONT SEAT Sameer Nair, CEO, Applause Entertainment; (below) a still from *Scam 1992: The Harshad Mehta Story*



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The 40-odd web shows that Applause Entertainment has made over the past five years have premiered across six major streaming platforms. Eleven of these released in 2022 alone, including *Humble Politician Nograj* (Voot select), *Bhaukaal* (MX Player) and *Rudra: The Edge of Darkness* (Disney+ Hotstar). This month, the third season of Applause's hit legal drama *Criminal Justice* (2019–) releases on Disney+Hotstar. Though company CEO Sameer Nair doesn't think of Applause as a "content factory", the Mumbai-based content studio has done much to meet the demand of OTT platforms, all of whom seem locked in a race to hold on to subscribers with new programming.

For Applause to become a frontrunner in the OTT programming space, Nair says the studio uses a "hub-and-spoke model"—it first funds and develops a show, then licenses it. While other creators like The Viral Fever and Pocket Aces also use the same model, their shows quite obviously lack Applause's scale and budgets. "We are in the business of making life easier for platforms," explains Nair. "The bulk of heavy lifting is done by us. They just have to make a buy-or-no-buy decision." Nair quotes a dialogue from one of his marquee shows, *Scam 1992: The Harshad Mehta Story* (2020): "*Risk hai toh ishq hai.*" The risks mostly have paid off. *Rudra*, for instance, has become one of 2022's most-watched titles. "We are building a brand, creating IP," says Nair. "We are getting rich slowly."

It does help that Applause is backed by billionaire Kumar Mangalam Birla, who roped in Nair to head it in 2017. Nair, with his decades-long experience in TV, knew one thing before he ventured into streaming—programming had "to be significantly better and different from what comes on TV". This meant that budgets shot up. "A series is like making two or three movies," he says.

Over time, Nair and his 30-member-strong creative team have also diversified into features, documentaries and podcasts. Its first film, *The Rapist* (2021), directed by Aparna Sen, won the Kim Jiseok Award at the Busan International Film Festival. The studio has finished another six films. Wanting to foray into animated programming, Applause has also acquired the complete catalogue of *Amar Chitra Katha*. On its ever-brimming slate are projects like *Tanaav*, an adaptation of Israeli drama *Fauda* (2015–), and an adaptation of Ramchandra Guha's Gandhi books, which will see the *Scam 1992* director-actor duo of Hansal Mehta and Pratik Gandhi collaborate again. It has even set shop in Chennai to bolster its regional presence. It may not be a "content factory" but Applause knows how to be industrious. ■

- Suhani Singh



PUNJABI

Beautiful Billo (ZEE5)

Wanting to give her child a better future, a pregnant Billo (Neeru Bajwa) finds herself in the UK illegally. Though the film makes you laugh, it does so without making light of migrants or their stories.



BENGALI

Murder by the Sea (Hoichoi)

Things get murky when a crime novelist starts probing a real-life murder. Anjan Dutta directs an ensemble cast for this web show that resembles Nordic noir and some British whodunits.